

Experimental works

Ives became a student at Yale University in 1894. He studied with the composer Horatio Parker, a graduate of Munich's Royal Music School, who encouraged his pupil to set German Romantic poems and master advanced contrapuntal forms. Ives supplemented his formal European-style training by running experiments with the Hyperion Theater Orchestra, creating innovative music from hymn tunes, college songs, and dances played simultaneously in different keys and at different speeds.

After graduating in 1898, Ives spent a decade in New York working in insurance and as a part-time church organist. Unrestrained by the need to make money from composition, he experimented with daring harmonies and complex rhythmic patterns. In 1908, he married Harmony Twichell, the sister of a Yale roommate. During their engagement, he composed a series of visionary, highly original works, *The Unanswered Question* and *Central Park in the Dark* among them. A few years after their marriage, the couple built a house near Danbury, where they spent many summers.